

FREE PLAYBOOK FOR SERIOUS LIFTERS

The Lifter's Guide to Pain-Free Gains

Dr. Sam Englander, PT, DPT

Top Performance Physical Therapy | Denver, Colorado

Table of Contents

1. The Real Problem: Why Lifters Stop Training (and Why They Shouldn't)
2. Protocol #1: Knee Pain During Squats — Scaling vs. Stopping
3. Protocol #2: Lower Back Tension in the Deadlift
4. Protocol #3: Shoulder Pain in the Bench Press
5. Protocol #4: Hip Mobility for Olympic Lifts
6. Protocol #5: Elbow Strain in Overhead Pressing
7. Protocol #6: Ankle Limitation in Front Rack Position
8. Protocol #7: 7-Day Loading Strategy for Meet Prep
9. Next Steps: How to Get Your Personalized Program

The Real Problem: Why Lifters Stop Training

You've trained for years to build strength. You know what max effort feels like. You've earned your numbers.

Then pain shows up. And someone tells you to stop training. Rest. Ice. Avoid the movement. Come back in 6 weeks.

But that's not how strength athletes think. You don't want to stop. You want to keep training. Keep competing. Keep building.

The problem: Most rehab is built for people who DON'T train hard. It's designed around rest and avoidance.

This guide is different. It's built for lifters. For serious athletes who refuse to stop.

The protocols inside aren't about resting your way to health. They're about **scaling** your way there — modifying, adjusting, and evolving your training while you fix the root cause.

No pulled lifts. No destroyed volume. No broken programs.

Just smarter training.

"Scale the movement. Keep the stimulus. Build strength."

Protocol #1

Knee Pain During Squats

Problem: Sharp pain in the knee at the bottom of the squat. Fear of causing further damage. Most advice: stop squatting, rest, ice. Wrong approach for competitive athletes.

Root Cause: Quad dominance combined with anterior knee tracking fault and ankle mobility limitation. The knee is taking stress it shouldn't because the ankle and hip aren't doing their share.

The Fix

- Tibialis anterior activation — 3 sets x 10 reps, daily
- Belt squats or pin squats — same stimulus, reduced knee demand
- Ankle mobility: couch stretch — 2 sets x 1 min daily

Loading: Reduce squat depth by 2 inches, maintain weight, keep same rep scheme. Add 0.5 inches per week as pain resolves.

Timeline: Most athletes see 50% improvement in 2-3 weeks. Full resolution in 4-6 weeks.

Example: Squatting 315 for 5x5? Reduce depth 2 inches — keep 315, keep 5x5. Week 2: add 0.5 inches depth. Week 3: add another 0.5 inches. Continue to full depth.

"Scale the movement, not the commitment. You're still squatting heavy."

Protocol #2

Lower Back Tension in the Deadlift

Problem: Lower back soreness and tightness during or after deadlifts. Can range from mild fatigue to sharp pain. Most athletes push through or stop completely.

Root Cause: Hip extension limitations combined with anterior core weakness and a positioning fault. The lower back compensates for what the hips and core aren't doing.

The Fix

- Banded pull-throughs — 3 sets x 12 reps, 2x per week
- Dead bugs or bird dogs — 3 sets x 10 reps, daily
- Trap bar deadlift or sumo variation — reduces spinal demand while keeping the stimulus

Loading: Reduce range of motion via block pulls (4-inch elevated surface), same weight and reps. Progress range as strength and pain tolerance improve.

Timeline: 3-4 weeks to significant improvement with consistent protocol application.

Example: Deadlifting 405 conventional 5x3? Switch to block pulls at 405 for 5x3. Week 2: 3-inch elevation. Week 3: 2 inches. Week 4: full range if pain-free.

"Your deadlift evolves. Your strength doesn't stop."

Protocol #3

Shoulder Pain in the Bench Press

Problem: Anterior shoulder pain, feeling of instability at lockout, or pain at the bottom of the press. One of the most common injuries that pulls athletes off the platform.

Root Cause: Scapular dyskinesis combined with rotator cuff weakness and excessive internal rotation. The shoulder is working without a stable base.

The Fix

- Band pull-aparts or face pulls — 3 sets x 15 reps, daily
- Floor press or safety bar bench — changes demand, same movement pattern
- Prone Y-T-W raises — 3 sets x 8 each position, 3x per week

Loading: Reduce range of motion via floor press OR change grip via safety bar. Maintain weight and volume — change the demand, not the stimulus.

Timeline: 2-3 weeks for pain reduction. 4-6 weeks for full strength return.

Example: Benching 285 for 3x5? Switch to floor press at 285 for 3x5 + 15 daily face pulls. Week 3: touch-and-go at 275. Week 4: full range at competition grip.

"Bench still happens. You're just training smarter."

Protocol #4

Hip Mobility for Olympic Lifts

Problem: Inability to get into a deep receiving position in the snatch or clean. The mobility wall limits depth, speed, and load — and creates injury risk under fatigue.

Root Cause: Hip capsule tightness combined with hamstring limitation and ankle mobility restriction. All three compound each other under load.

The Fix

- 90/90 stretch or butterfly stretch — 2 sets x 1 min daily
- Sled push or leg press — loads the pattern without requiring end-range mobility
- Tall snatches or snatches on plates — progresses receiving position in small increments

Loading: Use pause reps or partial range. Progress depth as mobility improves across sessions.

Timeline: Noticeable improvement in 1-2 weeks with daily mobility work.

Example: Day 1: tall snatches + 90/90 stretch 2x daily. Day 3: snatches on 2-inch plates. Day 5: 1-inch plates. Day 7: attempt full range.

"Mobility is an accessory. Train it like a lift."

Protocol #5

Elbow Strain in Overhead Pressing

Problem: Elbow pain during press, lockout discomfort, lateral epicondyle tenderness. Often misdiagnosed as tendinitis and treated with pure rest.

Root Cause: Excessive pronation combined with poor scapular stability and volume accumulation. The elbow is absorbing force the shoulder should be controlling.

The Fix

- Supinated pressing or dumbbell press — changes wrist and elbow angle immediately
- Plank holds or pushup holds — anterior core and shoulder stability under load
- Reverse flyes or band pull-aparts — addresses posterior shoulder weakness

Loading: Reduce volume by 20-30%. Focus on form and pause reps to re-establish control.

Timeline: 1-2 weeks for pain reduction with proper load management.

Example: Overhead pressing 205 for 5x5 (25 total reps). Reduce to 3x5 (15 reps). Add 2x5 supinated dumbbell press. Week 2: return to 4x5. Week 3: back to 5x5.

"Your press adapts. Your strength persists."

Protocol #6

Ankle Limitation in Front Rack Position

Problem: Cannot achieve adequate dorsiflexion to hold a proper front rack. Forces compensations in the knee, hip, and spine — creating injury risk up the chain.

Root Cause: Calf tightness, ankle capsule stiffness, and soleus limitation. Often combined with prior ankle sprains that were never fully rehabilitated.

The Fix

- Couch stretch or wall dorsiflexion stretch — 2 sets x 2 min daily
- Goblet squats or pause squats — builds strength directly in the required position
- Elevated heel squats or Anderson squats — loads the range you currently have

Loading: Use elevated heel or paused rack holds for reps. Progress range daily.

Timeline: Noticeable improvement in 1 week. Significant in 3-4 weeks with daily work.

Example: Day 1: couch stretch 2x2min + Anderson squats at 135. Day 2: add goblet squat holds 2x30sec. Day 4: reduce heel elevation. Day 7: attempt front rack without elevation.

"Ankle mobility is trainable. Your lifts don't wait."

Protocol #7

7-Day Loading Strategy for Meet Prep

Problem: Pain flares during meet prep when volume and intensity peak simultaneously. Athletes must manage readiness without sacrificing competition performance.

Root Cause: Volume + intensity + fatigue + inadequate recovery + overuse patterns. Meet prep amplifies everything — good and bad.

The Fix

- Day 1: Heavy single/double work — max effort, minimal volume
- Day 2: Recovery day — mobility, activation, no heavy load
- Day 3: Volume work — 10-15 rep range, secondary lifts
- Day 4: Accessory focus — 3-4 exercises, pain-free range only
- Day 5: Dynamic effort — speed + lighter load, technique focus
- Day 6: Upper/lower split depending on sport
- Day 7: Complete rest or light mobility only

Loading: Reduce volume 15-20% each week leading to meet. Maintain intensity via RPE, not total reps.

Timeline: Manage pain across the full prep cycle without loss of meet readiness.

Example: 4 weeks out: 95% intensity / 100% volume. 3 weeks: 95% / 85%. 2 weeks: 90% / 70%. Deload: 80% / 50%. Meet week: Competition.

"Meet prep is sacred. Pain management is part of the plan."

You've Got the Protocols. Now What?

These 7 protocols work because they follow a simple principle:

Train around the problem. Don't run from it.

Scale the movement. Keep the stimulus. Build strength.

But every lifter is different. Your pain point might need a custom application. Your program might need a specific modification. Your timeline might be different.

That's where a personalized assessment comes in. Book a free 15-minute discovery call. Tell me about your pain, your goals, your training. I'll give you a specific protocol adjustment and tell you if you need a full evaluation.

Either way, you'll have a plan. **And you'll keep training.**

Schedule Your Free Discovery Call:

<https://drsampt.github.io/book-a-call/>

Book Your Full Evaluation:

<https://l.btrr.to/VBM4z>